LECTURE 11

History of the Indian Ocean as a Connected Space

Trade, Mobility, Empire, Ecology, Religion, and Institutions

- **A connected space —** *not a collection of isolated regions*
- **Links across —** *East Africa, the Middle East, South Asia, Southeast Asia, and China*

Prof Jayati Bhattacharya
Email: iimkjayati@gmail.com

Key readings:

- *K. N. Chaudhuri, "Unity and Disunity of Indian Ocean History"*
- *Tirthankar Roy, "The Indian Ocean Trade, 1500–1800"*

What Does “Connected Space” Mean?

Connection does not mean sameness — it means structured interaction across distance.

- **Routes —** *Maritime pathways structured by wind, geography and custom.*
- **Shared commercial practices —** *Common norms of trade, credit and exchange across regions.*
- **Migration —** *People moved and settled, carrying skills, language and ties with them.*
- **Religious networks —** *Faith communities linked distant regions through belief and pilgrimage.*
- **Political and military encounters —** *Conflict and diplomacy were also forms of connection, not its opposite.*

DISCUSSION

Was the Indian Ocean connected mainly by trade — or did trade itself depend on deeper connections like climate, religion, and migration?

PART I

Why the Indian Ocean Matters in World History

One of the oldest and most important arenas of interregional exchange in world history.

- **Long-distance trade long before European empire —** *The ocean had its own deep history, not a prelude to Europe.*

- **Movement of goods, people, technologies, languages, and religious ideas —** *Exchange went far beyond commodities alone.*

- **Crucial to the histories of Islam, India, Southeast Asia, China, and East Africa —** *Central, not peripheral, to major world regions.*

- **Helps decenter Europe in global history —** *European expansion is only one chapter in a much longer story.*

SIGNIFICANT POINT

Indian Ocean history is not a "prelude" to European expansion — it has its own long historical logic.

PART I

Unity in the Large, Disunity in the Small

The Indian Ocean can be a meaningful historical unit — without being uniform.

- **Challenges the "too diverse to compare" view —** *Chaudhuri argues the region can still be studied as a whole.*
- **Inspired partly by Braudel's Mediterranean —** *A model for writing history across a shared sea, not a single culture.*
- **Unity at the level of space, time, and structures —** *Shared maritime routes, long-distance trade, and recurring political patterns.*
- **Always accompanied by internal differentiation —** *Food, clothing, housing, authority and religion varied enormously.*

ANCHORING IDEA

The Indian Ocean was connected, not uniform — this idea can anchor the entire lecture. We can return to it later when discussing trade and empire.

PART I

A Meeting Ground of Civilisations

The ocean enabled contact across civilisational boundaries — not just goods across water.

- **Islam, Sanskritic India, Southeast Asia, and Confucian China** — *Four major, overlapping civilizational formations in Chaudhuri's account.*
- **Distinct but interactive** — *Each retained its own character while constantly engaging with the others.*
- **Circulation, borrowing, translation, and conflict** — *Contact took many forms, not only peaceful exchange.*
- **Categories worth questioning** — *Useful for argument, but also debatable — they can seem too neat.*

CAUTION

These four categories simplify a messier reality — treat them as a starting point for discussion, not a fixed map.

PART I

Material Life and Ecology as Historical Evidence

Everyday life and environment reveal connection and difference just as clearly as trade or politics.

- **Food systems —** *Wheat and bread zones versus rice zones reflect deep ecological and cultural difference.*
- **Clothing and housing —** *Marked status, ritual, gender, climate and authority across the region.*
- **Monsoon winds —** *Structured seasonal navigation and made long-distance sailing predictable.*
- **Ecological zones —** *Shaped agriculture, settlement, architecture and political power; dry zones differed from wet zones.*

KEY TAKEAWAY

Global history here is not only about kings and fleets — connectivity was seasonal, patterned, and material.

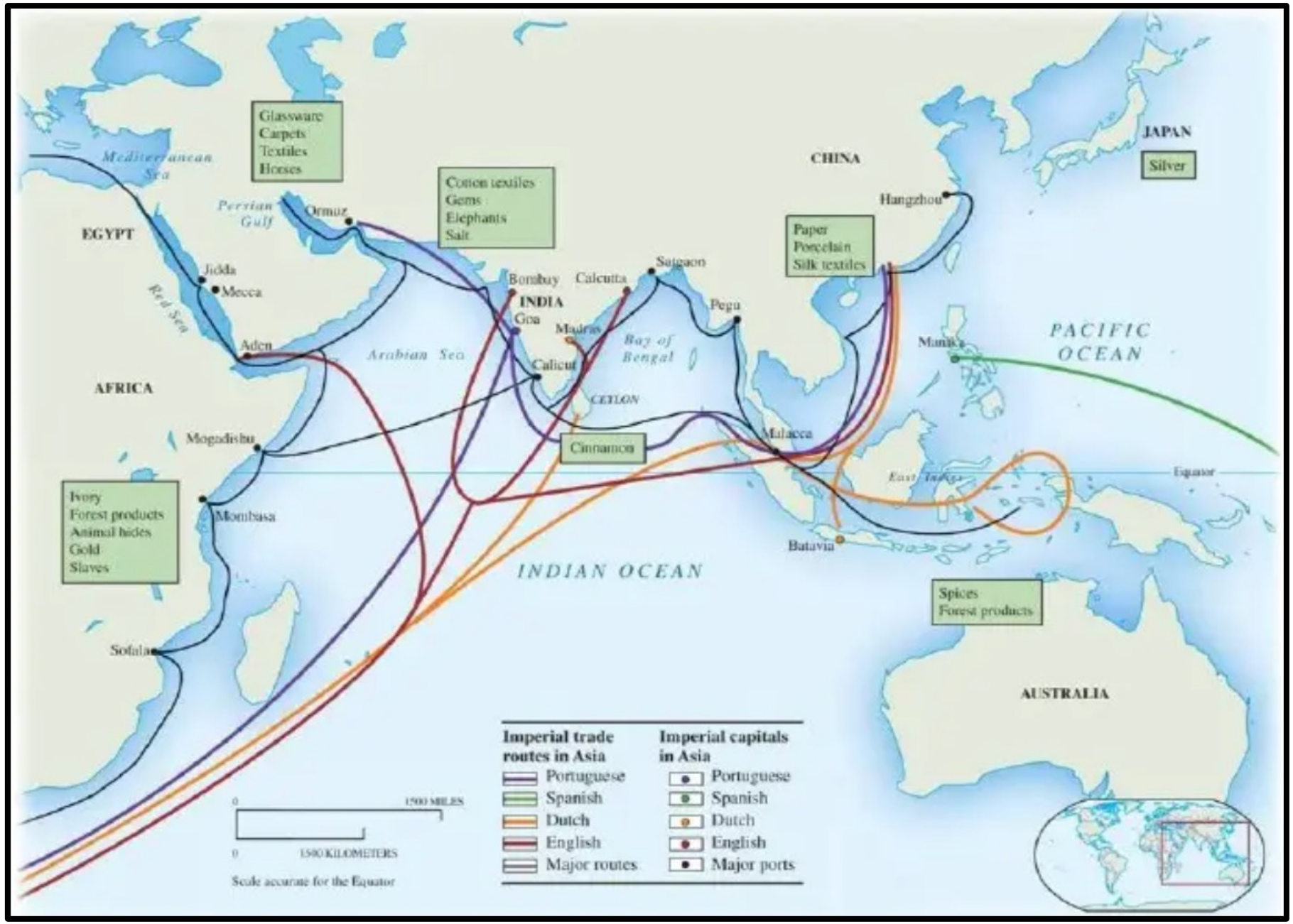
PART II · TRADE AND INSTITUTIONS

Roy: India at the Center of the Indian Ocean World

India was already central to Indian Ocean trade long before Europeans arrived.

- **India sat at the center of the "great arc" of Asian trade —** *A hinge between western and eastern trading circuits.*
- **Indian ports were transit points, markets, and production centers —** *Multiple roles at once, not a single function.*
- **Major exports: textiles, rice, indigo, cotton —** *Goods that Asian, and later European, markets both depended on.*
- **Major imports: bullion, horses, luxury goods, spices for re-export —** *India both supplied and consumed across the system.*

EUROPEAN EXPANSION IN THE INDIAN OCEAN MARITIME SPACE



PART II

Merchant Networks and Port Cities

A crowded, functioning commercial world existed long before Europeans arrived.

- **Gujarati Muslims, Mapilla Muslims, Chulia and Telugu Chetti merchants —** *Sophisticated Asian trading communities operating across the region.*

- **Combined trade, shipping, shipbuilding, credit, and mobility —** *Fully developed commercial capacity, not simple bartering.*

- **Key ports: Calicut, Cambay, Surat, Malacca, Aden, Hormuz —** *Nodes linking oceanic and overland trade routes.*

- **Ports as interfaces —** *Connected sea, land, and political authority; cargo passed through many merchant groups.*

CLARIFICATION

Europeans entered a crowded and functioning commercial world — not an empty stage.

PART II

The Portuguese: Entry, Violence, and Limits

The Portuguese changed the Indian Ocean — but they never fully controlled it.

- **Opened the Cape route to Asia —** *Tried to bypass the older Red Sea and Gulf routes.*
- **Combined treaties, fortified ports, naval coercion, and religious hostility —** *A mixed strategy, not force alone.*
- **Key bases: Goa, Cochin, Hormuz, Malacca —** *Strategic footholds rather than territorial control.*
- **Monopoly remained partial and unstable —** *Older networks persisted alongside and around them.*

CAUTION

The Portuguese were not all-powerful — Roy shows their reach was real, but uneven.

PART II

Companies and New Commercial Forms

European power was institutional as well as military.

- **Joint-stock finance —** *Pooled capital at a scale earlier merchants could rarely match.*
- **Monopoly charters —** *State-backed exclusive trading rights over defined regions and goods.*
- **Risk sharing at scale —** *Spread commercial risk across many investors, sustaining long voyages.*
- **Forts, factories, harbors, and armed shipping —** *Organizational capacity to project power continuously, not just once.*

READING CONNECTION

One of Roy's strongest points: organizational difference mattered as much as military force.

PART II

Violence, Adaptation, and Indian Agency

Violence mattered, but Europeans still depended heavily on Indian commercial actors.

- **Force disrupted the Asian spice trade —** *The Portuguese used coercion, and Europeans often fought each other too.*
- **Asian commercial worlds were not purely peaceful before 1500 —** *Competition and conflict predate European arrival.*
- **Indian brokers, financiers, and shipwrights sustained commerce —** *Procurement, credit and shipbuilding often stayed in Indian hands.*
- **Empire grew through entanglement, not simple replacement —** *Adaptation to local politics and credit systems was essential.*

DISCUSS

If Europeans depended so heavily on Indian merchants and producers, what exactly was new about European power?

PART II

Port Cities and Institutional Change

Bombay, Madras, and Calcutta were new kinds of political-commercial spaces — not just new ports.

- **More autonomous from inland powers —** *Less tied to existing regional political authority.*
- **More ocean-facing than older ports —** *Oriented toward maritime trade from the outset.*
- **Greater role for commercial law and contract enforcement —** *Predictable rules attracted capital and merchants.*
- **Became bases for expanding company power —** *Commercial footholds that gradually grew into political ones.*

READING CONNECTION

Roy treats these cities as a major turning point in both Indian Ocean and Indian history.

PART II

From Trade to Empire

Trade did not mechanically produce empire — but it created the conditions that made empire possible.

- **Fortified trading settlements accumulated power —** *Commercial footholds slowly became political ones.*
- **Company organisation blurred trade and sovereignty —** *Companies acted as both merchants and quasi-states.*
- **Mughal decline altered the balance of power —** *Weakening central authority opened space for new actors.*
- **Commercial cities became staging grounds for conquest —** *Political authority followed commercial infrastructure.*

BRIDGE POINT

This is the bridge between economic history and imperial history — the hinge of the whole lecture.

Comparing Chaudhuri and Roy

Two ways of thinking about the same connected world —complementary, not opposed.

Chaudhuri	Roy
Macro-historical and theoretical	Empirical and political-economic
Focus on unity/disunity	Focus on trade and institutional change
Civilisational structures	Merchant networks, companies, ports
Longue durée	1500–1800 transformation
Connected space as theory	Connected space as commercial practice

PART III

How Far Does “Connected Space” Take Us?

The framework is powerful — but it also has real limits.

Strengths

- Breaks national history boundaries
- Decenters Europe
- Shows mobility and interdependence

Limits

- May flatten local differences
- May privilege merchants over labourers and peasants
- May understate coercion, slavery, and inequality
- May make connection seem smoother than it was

Connected for whom? On whose terms?

CONCLUSION

The Indian Ocean as a Connected but Uneven World

- **Unity did not mean sameness —** *Coherence at a macro level coexisted with deep regional difference.*
- **Trade was central, but not the whole story —** *Ecology, religion, migration and empire also mattered.*
- **European expansion transformed, but did not create, Indian Ocean connectivity —** *Long before 1500, the system already worked.*
- **A connected, contested, and constantly re-made historical world —** *The best final takeaway for the whole lecture.*

The Indian Ocean became historically significant not because it erased difference, but because it connected different worlds in durable, unequal, and transformative ways.

GLOSSARY OF KEY TERMS USED IN K.N CHAUDHURI'S ARTICLE

Term	Meaning in the essay
Longue duree	Long-term historical structures and slow change
Invariance	Deep continuity despite surface variation
Structuralism	Search for underlying organising principles
Unity/disunity	Simultaneous connectedness and difference
Logical space	Conceptual field within which meaning and classification operate
Mapping	Projecting one structure onto another for comparison
Isomorphism	Structural equivalence between different forms
Temporal structure	The explanatory significance of different scales of time
Civilisational identity	Large cultural-historical formations like Islam or Confucian China

GLOSSARY OF KEY TERMS USED IN T. ROY'S CHAPTER

Term	Meaning in the chapter
Littoral	Coastal commercial zone
Joint-stock company	Capital pooled by shareholders with shared risk
Monopoly charter	Exclusive trading rights granted by the Crown
Broker	Intermediary linking company and local producers/merchants
Factory	Trading station, not an industrial factory in the modern sense
Commercial law	Legal framework supporting contracts, property, and trade
Port city sovereignty	Urban control that allowed merchants and companies to shape governance
Indo-European trade	Trade linking Indian and European commercial systems within the wider Indian Ocean